

Commencement Speech

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Thank you, Dean Triantis. I'm honored to be here today, representing the incredible class of 2026.

Today marks a big change in all of our lives, like the calm before a storm, when everything feels both **certain** and **completely** unknown.

At Carey, in moments of uncertainty, many of us found ourselves staring out at the harbour - looking for clarity in the water.

And, **if** you'd looked closely enough, you'd see them... jellyfish.

They move with the current, but have their own direction.
Like a quiet purpose.

Some are translucent, some in colors you do not expect; and some actually light up!

I have thought about jellyfish **a lot** this year.

I think in **many** ways, **WE**, are like them.

Look around this room...look at your classmates, your families, and the friends taking too many photos, because one is never enough!

Look at the people who have travelled across cities, states, and countries, just to be here with us today. They are here to celebrate not just a degree, but everything it took to get there. The hard choices; the quiet sacrifices; and the **courage** it took for so many of us to move into a new world.

I am incredibly lucky that my mum is here with me today. But I want to take a moment to acknowledge the loved ones who are watching from afar, across time zones, and conflicted skies.

Please know that your love is **felt** in this room.

And to my **dear** classmates, your Carey family is proud of you.

And yes, we are all collectively praying that the wifi stays strong!

I can **feel** the pride in the air. Joy. Relief. And maybe **still** a little uncertainty?

Underneath it all, is the fact that **none of us** got here in a straight line.

We come from different countries, careers... and different versions of ourselves. Some of us did this full-time, some part-time, and some alongside jobs, families, and entire lives already in motion. But we are all **united**, by our passion to learn.

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For me, Carey was never **just** a school.

It's Officer Allen, at the front desk, greeting me with a big smile; making the place feel human.

It's my classmates, who began as assigned strangers in group projects, across time zones, and with different definitions of what "done by Sunday" means. They became the people **I call** when life gets heavy.

And sometimes, the weight is real. Like last year, I worked through exams and group projects while surrounded by the sounds of machines and uncertainty. I spent finals week, across the world, in an ICU, praying that my grandmother (who in part raised me) would get better.

Michael Tyler, my academic coach, carried me through it.

My incredible professors, carried me.

And my classmates carried me. Even though **I was** the project lead, my team enthusiastically presented to our consulting clients in my absence, **and** ensured we took the prize for best presentation! That, is collaborative leadership in action. *(smile)*

In that moment, I understood what it meant to be carried - and what it **means** to belong at Carey.

And I know I am not the only person in this room, with a story like that.

Carey refined us. It taught us to hold ambition, and humanity, in the same hand.

To pivot, when plans fell apart, and keep going. **That** is also called relentless advancement. The kind that asks more of you - and then **shows you**, that you were capable of **more** than you knew.

Carey helped me understand what I already had.

My friend and classmate Josephine, once told me, “Be a proud circle. Don’t try to be a square.”

I came here believing, I was **only** a designer. My education had always been unconventional - learning poetry in the forest, math beside a lotus pond, and a strong foundation in human-centered design.

And now, I am leaving **knowing** that I’m not just one thing, I’m multi-faceted: creative **and** analytical, non-linear, **yet** structured.

Living with imagination, alongside the spreadsheets.

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I know this all sounds great, but the truth is, that by myself I’m a lone jellyfish, floating at the mercy of the tide.

While on their own, jellyfish seem fragile, when they come together, they become a **bloom**.

A jellyfish bloom **lights up** the water around it, reshaping the entire ecosystem. And that, is what we became here - people who can change the world **together**.

This community, is what un-waver-ing humanity looks like. Not just phrases on a wall, but values we **actually live**.

The world we are entering is obsessed with speed, optimization, and efficiency.

So let's build it, let's scale it, and let's lead. Let's **be, excellent.**

And as we leave this place: let's take the skills, the ambition, and **everything** we learnt here, and reach back for someone else.

Be the person who stays on the call a little longer.

Be the person who asks how someone is, and genuinely wants to hear them respond.

Be the person who makes room, and the one who **brings others** in.

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If there is one thing I hope we leave with, it's this:
our greatest advantage, will not be **what we know**. It will be **how**, we **move**, through this world.

With rigor; with curiosity; and with humanity. **EVEN** under pressure.

The harbour is right here. And the water **beyond it**, is **vast**. Let's go out there **together** and light it up! (*smile*)

We are not finished...we're just getting started.

Thank you, and Congratulations class of 2026!